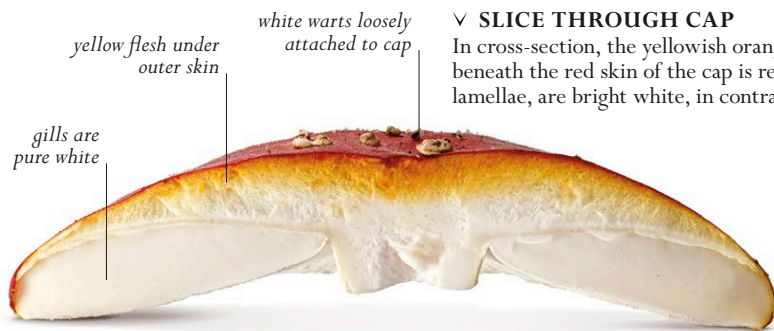




✓ SLICE THROUGH CAP

In cross-section, the yellowish orange flesh immediately beneath the red skin of the cap is revealed. The gills, or lamellae, are bright white, in contrast.

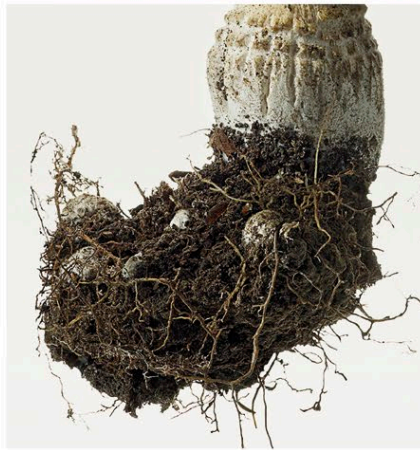
✓ SCALES

The white or pale yellow warty scales are all that remain of an enveloping veil of tissue that once enclosed the young cap.



^ GILLS

The fly agaric's radiating gills are of different lengths, some stopping well short of the stem. This allows them to fill the available space, ensuring that spore production is maximized.



STEM BASE >

The base is swollen and club-like, with warty ridges encircling the upper part of the bulb. Threads of mycelium (fungal tissue) connect to fine tree roots below the soil.

< FAMILIAR FUNGUS

The fly agaric changes shape dramatically as it grows and expands, but the colour and key characters usually remain constant. The cap may fade to yellow if there has been persistent rain. Its common name refers to an old folk remedy – the red skin of the cap was used in a saucer of milk to poison annoying house flies.

GROWTH STAGES OF A FLY AGARIC



^ BABY BUTTON

The young button is completely enclosed in a warty universal veil.

^ BROKEN VEIL

The stem has started to grow, and the universal veil on the cap has split apart.

^ GROWING CAP

The cap expands, with the partial veil still attached underneath.

^ GILLS APPEAR

The partial veil starts to tear, forming the ring and exposing the gills above.

^ SPORE DISPERSAL

Spores grow on the exposed gills and are then released into the air.

^ OLD AGE

At the end of its life the cap coloration fades and the cap may turn upwards.